

CHINEMELU OKAFOR

Harvard University Government Department
Cambridge, Massachusetts 02138

Email: cokafor@g.harvard.edu
Website: www.chinemeluokafor.com

Research Interests	Comparative politics; political economy; public economics; economic development; economic history; narrative economics; MSME development in emerging markets; international economics and trade	
Education	Harvard University	Cambridge, MA
	Ph.D. Government	2028 (<i>expected</i>)
	<i>Committee:</i> Melani Cammett (chair), Mashail Malik, Nathan Nunn, Pia Raffler, Awa Ambra Seck	
	Princeton University	Princeton, NJ
	Emerging Scholars in Political Science Program	August 2021
	The George Washington University	Washington, DC
	M.A. Applied Economics, <i>Dean's Award</i>	May 2018
	The University of Michigan	Ann Arbor, MI
	B.A. Economics, B.A. International Studies	May 2015
Works in Progress	Protest Matters: The Effects of Protests on Economic Redistribution [NBER working paper] The Effects of Women-Led Protests on Gender Gaps in Political Participation [Abstract]	
Selected Teaching	Harvard: Fall '24 '25 - Public Economics (ECON 1410), Stan Veuger Harvard: Spring '25 - Evaluating the Impact of Public Policies (GOV 1737), Prof. Michael Hiscox Harvard: Spring '25 '26 - Business & Entrepreneurship in Africa (HBSMBA 1555), Hakeem Belo-Osagie	
Academic Affiliations	Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Graduate Student Associate, (<i>renewed x2</i>)	August 2026
	Harvard Center for International Development, PhD Affiliate	January 2025
	Harvard Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Graduate Student Affiliate	October 2022
	London Business School's – African Research Councillors Programme Collaborator	May 2022
Selected Presentations	American Political Science Association Annual Meeting (<i>2026</i>) Harvard Center for African Studies Contested Realities Workshop (<i>2025</i>) London Business School, Wheeler Institute - African History Through the Lens of Economics (<i>2022</i>)	
Professional Distinctions	Econometric Society Africa Summer School (AFSS)	June 2026
	Association for Comparative Economic Studies (ACES) Summer School	July 2025
	American Political Science Association Member Spotlight	July 2025
	Harvard Department of Government Karl Deutsch Fellowship	August 2021
	Harvard Graduate School of Arts and Sciences Graduate Prize Fellowship	August 2021
	American Political Science Association Diversity Fellowship	December 2020
Selected Awards	Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Dissertation Writing Fellowship August 2026 Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Pre (<i>x2</i>) & Mid-dissertation Grant April 2026 Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, GSA Grant (<i>x2</i>) October 2025 John C. Hansen & Katherine Vogelheim, Research Grant (<i>x2</i>) January 2026 Harvard Center for African Studies, Travel Grant May 2025 Harvard Government Department, Women and Politics Research Grant April 2025 Harvard Jens Aubrey Westengard Scholarship May 2024	

Forbes 30 Under 30 N. America: Education - Founder, Research in Color Foundation November 2022
 Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Summer Language Grant April 2022
 Best Overall Performance in the Applied Economics Master's Program, *Dean's Award* May 2018

Professional Service

The Annual Review of Economics

Harvard Concentration Advisor, Thesis Advisor and Non-Resident Tutor August 2024 - Present

Harvard Resident Tutor, *Winthrop House* August 2021 - August 2023

Specialities: French Language, Public Service, First-gen Low-income, Economics, and Government

The Research In Color Foundation

May 2019 - Present

Founder and President

Founded and lead Research In Color a 501(c)(3) non-profit which seeks to increase the number and improve retention of historically excluded scholars in economics and economics-adjacent disciplines.

Research Experience

White House Council of Economic Advisers (*took leave from PhD*)

Washington, DC

Staff Economist

August 2023 - August 2024

Advisors: Dr. Sandile Hlatshwayo

Areas of focus: International Economics and Trade; Section 201 & 301 Tariffs

Selected Projects: 2024 Economic Report of the President, Chapter 4, *Council of Economic Advisers*

Emerging Scholars in Political Science Program

Princeton, NJ

Predocutorial Research Specialist

August 2019 - August 2021

Advisors: Prof. Leonard Wantchekon

Area of focus: Historical applied microeconomics;

Digitized historical maps of Nigeria in QGIS to support ongoing research on the long-run effects of colonial missionary education on present-day living standards, occupation, and political participation

Empirical Studies of Conflict Project

Princeton, NJ

Research Specialist II

September 2018 - August 2019

Advisors: Prof. Tarek Ghani and Prof. Jake Shapiro

Areas of focus: Natural resource extraction and conflict in Sub-Saharan Africa;

Preprocessed spatial data and created interactive map of Africa by merging firm-level ownership identifiers of extractive sites in oil, gas, and mining, to instances of violent conflict

Selected Projects: Mining Competition and Violent Conflict in Africa: Pitting Against Each Other

The International Finance Corporation (IFC)

Washington, DC

Research Assistant

February - October 2018

Advisors: Dr. Tristan Reed and Dr. Alexandros Ragoussis

Areas of focus: Private sector firm development in Sub-Saharan Africa;

Created indicators of infrastructure access and ran synthetic panel fixed effects regressions to measure inclusiveness and equality of markets to electric power and water for households

Selected Projects: Making It Big: Why Developing Countries Need More Large Firms, *IFC* 2020; Creating Impact: The Promise of Impact Investing, *IFC* 2019;

Beyond Capital: Monitoring Development Outcomes of Multinational Enterprises, *World Bank* 2018

The World Bank

Washington, DC

Consultant

June - August 2017

Advisors: Kinley Salmon and Nabila Assaf

Areas of focus: Major challenges to firm operations in post-conflict settings;

Conducted statistical hypothesis testing to investigate challenges to Syrian firms including access to economic infrastructure, supply disruptions, and loss of skilled workers

Selected Projects: Surviving Firms of the Syrian Arab Republic, *World Bank* 2018

Skills

RStudio, R Shiny, STATA, L^AT_EX, ArcGIS, Qualtrics, JavaScript, Microsoft Office Suite

Languages

English (Native proficiency), French (Upper-intermediate proficiency), Igbo (Passive proficiency)